without telling her and before she had finished. ‘I have been making a sketch of Dost Mohammad and his family,’ Emily reported somewhat tetchily to her sister in England, ‘and he set off this morning for the upper provinces, leaving me with one of their nephews unsketched. So this morning, with great activity I got up early, and Colvin abstracted the nephew from the steamer and brought him to sit for his picture before breakfast. The nephew is very like the picture of Judas Iscariot, but he is a fine subject. Considering Colvin had no breakfast, he seemed to talk Persian with wonderful animation.’[107]

The situation in Afghanistan had begun to deteriorate rapidly soon after Dost Mohammad’s departure from Calcutta. News had arrived a fortnight later that a Tory government had been elected in London, and after mulling over his options, Lord Auckland resigned as Governor General. Lord Ellenborough, the man who had originally written the memo that sent Burnes up the Indus ten years earlier, was appointed to replace him.

A week later, the news of Burnes’s murder and the fast unravelling of Lord Auckland’s entire Afghan strategy arrived in Bengal by courier. The first despatch to make it to Government House was a short note from General Sale written three weeks earlier in Jalalabad telling Auckland of the first rumours of disaster in Kabul and of his own encirclement. ‘I need not tell you that these communications very greatly distress me,’ Auckland wrote to Sir Jasper Nicholls, the Commander-in-Chief, that night. ‘They leave room for very formidable and serious speculation. I would not however speak of my own feelings. The question is, what is to be done?’

He then laid out various options, but like his generals in Kabul the stream of depressing news seemed to paralyse him and from the beginning he opposed the idea of an immediate military response. ‘I propose to have a special Council tomorrow,’ he wrote, ‘but it seems to me that we are not to think of marching fresh armies for the reconquest of that which we are likely to lose . . . I fear that the Afghan national spirit has been generally roused.’[108]

The truth was that Auckland had already realised months earlier that his whole Afghan policy had been catastrophically mistaken and was in danger of bankrupting the entire Indian government. Now with disaster looming, and with his treasury empty, he had no hesitation in taking the decision that he should simply write off the entire project and not throw any further resources into what was clearly a losing battle.